appetite among Indian officials to do this). Whether or not New Delhi reaches out to the HN, the evolution of its policy approach towards the Afghan insurgents remains a cause of concern for Pakistan. India's engagement with the Afghan Taliban would reduce Pakistan's indispensability for the group. In such a scenario, either Islamabad will have to increase financial support for these groups (to keep them from breaking away), or use active coercion and blackmail to prevent them from gravitating towards New Delhi. Given the history of India's support to the Baloch and Pashtunistan movements, this is an entirely credible threat.

Baloch and Pashtun cards

Somewhere between Islamabad's vehement allegations of India's role in fomenting separatism and violence in Pakistan (especially via Afghanistan), and New Delhi and Kabul's stony denials, lies the truth. Bereft of evidence, Pakistan's allegations of an omnipresent Indian hand behind its domestic troubles (in Balochistan, FATA, and Karachi) are treated, often correctly, as neuralgia of an insecure state marred by confused and conflicting nationalisms. But that does not absolve India politically, even if it has a strong legal defence to make. The buzz of India's covert successes in Balochistan is anything but subtle in Indian strategic circles, and the demand for such action is generally high. None other than Narayanan voiced such sentiments (of paying back Pakistan in the same coin) after the 2008 embassy bombing, and allegedly reached out to Saleh to seek Afghan help to target LeT assets.[114] Then foreign secretary, Menon, met with Karzai soon after the bombing and both agreed that 'the terrorist menace' should be 'rooted out from the region [read Pakistan] by targeting bases, recruitment places, and financial links', and agreed with Narayanan to counter Pakistan using force.[115] Islamabad's use of militants against both these countries inculcated a healthy appetite to make Pakistan pay.[116] So why has this not happened if one is to believe the Indian narrative (Narayanan denies that India undertook such offensive covert action against Pakistan)? Before we proceed with examining these issues, the reader should be forewarned that this section does not necessarily offer the 'truth' or even a comprehensive overview of the complex geopolitical